BEYOND CHIAVARI · FREE PLANNING KIT

Birthday Party Planning Kit

For kids' parties and milestone adult birthdays: 1st, sweet 16, 21st, and every decade from 30 to 90.

A great birthday party is about the person, not the price tag. This kit gives you a timeline, checklists, food amounts, game ideas, and a budget guide for every age from a first birthday to a ninetieth. Pick the sections that fit and skip the rest.

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Chairs, tables, linens, tents and more across Chicagoland, on one quote.

PART 1

Birthday Party Timeline

Spring and early summer fill up quickly in Chicago-area party venues, so book those dates earlier.

8 weeks out

- [ ] Choose the date and time, avoiding school breaks, holidays, and conflicts with big Chicago events.
- [ ] Set a budget and decide who is paying for what.
- [ ] Decide on a theme, color scheme, or activity for the guest of honor.
- [ ] Make a first-draft guest list and set a maximum headcount.
- [ ] Tour or book a venue: backyard, banquet hall, park pavilion, restaurant, or party room.
- [ ] Check park district permit rules and deadlines if you are using a public space.

6 weeks out

- [ ] Book entertainment: DJ, magician, face painter, balloon artist, bounce house, or live music.
- [ ] Book a photographer or ask a friend to take photos.
- [ ] Order or choose a cake, cupcakes, or dessert table.
- [ ] Reserve rentals: tables, chairs, linens, tent, dinnerware, glassware, and lighting.
- [ ] Send save-the-dates for milestone birthdays or out-of-town guests.

4 weeks out

- [ ] Send invitations by mail, email, or text with an RSVP date.
- [ ] Plan the menu and decide between catering, takeout, or home cooking.
- [ ] Order decorations, balloons, banners, and tableware.
- [ ] Plan the games, activities, or program.
- [ ] Decide on party favors or goody bags.
- [ ] Create a playlist with the guest of honor's favorites.

2 weeks out

- [ ] Follow up on RSVPs and note allergies.
- [ ] Confirm the headcount with the caterer, venue, and rental company.
- [ ] Buy food, drinks, and supplies that can be stored.
- [ ] Prepare a slideshow, memory book, or video tribute for milestone events.
- [ ] Confirm delivery windows and setup time with every vendor.
- [ ] Check the weather and arrange a tent or indoor space as backup.

1 week out

- [ ] Finalize the schedule and share it with helpers.
- [ ] Assign jobs: greeting guests, cake cutting, music, photos, cleanup.
- [ ] Buy candles, lighter, and cake knife.
- [ ] Pick up the gift table items and a card box.
- [ ] Prepare a rain or cold-weather plan for outdoor parties.

Day before

- [ ] Set up tables, chairs, and decorations if you can access the space.
- [ ] Prepare make-ahead food and chill drinks.
- [ ] Charge the camera and speaker.
- [ ] Confirm rentals will arrive when planned.
- [ ] Pack a party kit with tape, scissors, trash bags, and wipes.

Party day

- [ ] Receive and inspect rental deliveries.
- [ ] Finish decorations and food setup an hour before guests arrive.
- [ ] Set out welcome signs, name tags, and games.
- [ ] Greet each guest and introduce people who have not met.
- [ ] Take a group photo near the start of the party before people leave.
- [ ] Light the candles and sing at the time you planned.

After the party

- [ ] Return or prepare rentals for pickup.
- [ ] Send thank-you notes or messages within a week.
- [ ] Share photos with guests.
- [ ] Pay final vendor balances and tips.
- [ ] Write down what worked for next year.

PART 2

Party Planning Checklists by Age

1ST BIRTHDAY

- [ ] Keep the party short: 2 hours is plenty, ideally around nap schedules.
- [ ] Invite family and close friends with babies for a calm, small gathering.
- [ ] Set up a high chair for the guest of honor and extra seating for adults.
- [ ] Plan a smash cake for the baby and a regular cake for guests.
- [ ] Provide a quiet area for nursing, diaper changes, and naps.
- [ ] Choose soft, safe toys and avoid small parts.

KIDS 2 TO 12

- [ ] Plan 1.5 to 2 hours for young kids, and up to 3 hours for older kids.
- [ ] Choose one main activity and a backup, such as a bounce house, crafts, or field games.
- [ ] Ask parents about food allergies and whether they will stay or drop off.
- [ ] Set up child-sized tables and chairs and a separate adult seating area.
- [ ] Plan safe spaces for kids to run, with an adult watching each area.
- [ ] Prepare goody bags and a simple thank-you handout.

SWEET 16

- [ ] Ask the guest of honor what vibe they want: dance party, spa day, or dinner.
- [ ] Book a DJ, photo booth, or videographer.
- [ ] Create a guest list with a limit and decide whether parents attend.
- [ ] Plan a candle-lighting ceremony or slideshow if they want one.
- [ ] Arrange rides or a safe pickup plan for guests.
- [ ] Set clear rules about phones, alcohol, and curfew.

21ST BIRTHDAY

- [ ] Plan a venue with licensed service and ID checks.
- [ ] Arrange rideshare, designated drivers, or a shuttle.
- [ ] Plan food so guests do not drink on empty stomachs.
- [ ] Offer non-alcoholic options and water.
- [ ] Choose a few fun toasts or traditions.
- [ ] Keep photos, cups, and decor within a reasonable budget.

MILESTONE ADULT BIRTHDAYS (30, 40, 50, 60, 70, 80, 90)

- [ ] Ask the guest of honor what feels right: surprise or planned, big or small.
- [ ] Gather photos and stories from friends and family for a slideshow or memory book.
- [ ] Choose seating with easy access, ample lighting, and low noise for older guests.
- [ ] Arrange accessible parking and a shuttle if needed.
- [ ] Plan a short, warm toast program rather than a long one.
- [ ] Use rented comfortable chairs and enough tables so no one has to stand.

PART 3

Food and Drink Amounts

Rough planning quantities for a 2- to 3-hour party. Increase for dinner, longer events, or hearty eaters.

Item	Per person	20 guests	50 guests	100 guests
Appetizers (before a meal)	4 to 6 pieces	100 pieces	250 pieces	500 pieces
Main dish (entree)	6 to 8 oz	8 lb	20 lb	40 lb
Side dishes (total)	3 to 4 oz each	2 sides	3 sides	3 sides

Item	Per person	20 guests	50 guests	100 guests
Pizza (slices)	3 for kids, 2 to 3 for adults	6 large pies	15 large pies	30 large pies
Cake	1 slice	1 half sheet	2 half sheets	1 full sheet and a half sheet
Cupcakes	1.5	30	75	150
Soda, juice, and water	2 drinks first hour, 1 per hour after	40 to 60	100 to 150	200 to 300
Ice	1 to 1.5 lb	25 lb	60 lb	125 lb
Coffee (for evening events)	1 cup	20 cups	50 cups	100 cups
Beer, wine, and cocktails (adult events)	1 drink per hour per adult	40 to 60	100 to 150	200 to 300

PART 4

Games and Activities

- For toddlers: bubbles, sensory bins, soft blocks, and a simple music-and-dance circle.
- For ages 3 to 6: pin the tail, scavenger hunt, musical chairs, and a piñata.
- For ages 7 to 12: relay races, sack races, water balloon toss, and capture the flag.
- For teens: karaoke, a movie night, a photo booth with props, or a mini tournament.
- For sweet 16: a dance floor, a DJ, a candy bar, and a polaroid guest book.
- For adults: trivia about the guest of honor, a memory jar, and a toast circle.
- Run a this-or-that photo wall with past photos for milestone birthdays.
- Set up lawn games such as cornhole, giant Jenga, and bocce for backyard parties.
- Have a craft table for younger kids: decorate a cookie, make a crown, or paint a mask.
- Keep a quiet corner with coloring pages and books for kids who need a break.
- For rainy days: build an indoor obstacle course, hold a dance contest, or run a movie.
- Appoint an adult to run each game so the party stays on schedule.

PART 5

Rental Checklist for Birthday Parties

SEATING AND TABLES

- [ ] Order one adult chair for every adult guest.
- [ ] Add kid-sized tables and chairs for children under 7.
- [ ] Add a cake table, gift table, and drink station.
- [ ] Order cocktail tables for mingling at adult parties.
- [ ] Choose tablecloths in the party colors.

WEATHER AND AMBIANCE

- [ ] Rent a tent for backyard parties from May through October.
- [ ] Rent heaters for spring and fall evenings.
- [ ] Order string lights or lanterns for evening gatherings.
- [ ] Add a dance floor for teen and adult dance parties.
- [ ] Ask the rental company about fans for hot afternoons.

TABLEWARE

- [ ] Rent plates, forks, and glasses to avoid disposable waste.
- [ ] Order serving platters and chafing dishes if you are self-catering.
- [ ] Add pitchers and drink dispensers.
- [ ] Order extra napkins for cake and messy foods.

PART 6

Birthday Budget Split

Rough guide. Chicago-area prices vary widely by venue and guest count.



Category	Share	Your budget: $_____	Tip
Venue and rentals	25%	$_____	A backyard can cut this by half, but plan for tent and chair rentals.
Food and cake	35%	$_____	Order cake and desserts early and ask the caterer to pack leftovers.
Drinks	8%	$_____	Buy non-alcoholic drinks in bulk and rent a drink dispenser.
Entertainment and activities	12%	$_____	Book one memorable activity rather than many small ones.
Decor and invitations	8%	$_____	Use digital invitations and reusable decor.
Photos and keepsakes	5%	$_____	Ask a talented friend or hire a photographer for an hour.
Favors and thank-yous	3%	$_____	Skip favors or choose something useful.
Contingency	4%	$_____	Keep a cushion for extra guests and weather changes.

PART 7

Birthday Party Worksheet

GUEST OF HONOR AND AGE

DATE AND TIME

VENUE AND ADDRESS

THEME OR COLOR SCHEME

GUEST COUNT (EXPECTED AND CONFIRMED)

TOTAL BUDGET

CATERER OR FOOD PLAN

CAKE OR DESSERT ORDER

ENTERTAINMENT AND GAMES

RENTAL DELIVERY TIME

HELPERS AND THEIR JOBS

ALLERGIES AND SPECIAL NEEDS

WEATHER BACKUP PLAN

THANK-YOU NOTE LIST

NEXT STEP

Get every rental on one quote

Pick chairs, tables, linens, dinnerware, tents and decor from Chicago-area rental companies and see prices as you build your list at beyondchiavari.com/quote. Want a second set of eyes on your plan? Book a free planning call at beyondchiavari.com/book.

Planning rules of thumb only. Confirm counts, rules and timing with your venue and vendors. © Beyond Chiavari. Free to print and share for personal planning.